TALK SIX

6 When the Morning Stars Sang

"When the morning stars sang together, and all the sons of God shouted for joy."

JOB 38:7

Job sat in ashes, scraping his sores with a piece of broken pottery. He had lost his children, his property, and his health. He knew he had tried to live faithfully, and he could not understand why these things had happened. Much of the book of Job is a record of him trying to make sense of his suffering.

When the Lord finally answered out of a whirlwind, He asked Job a question: "Where wast thou when I laid the foundations of the earth?" Then He described that beginning as a time when "the morning stars sang together, and all the sons of God shouted for joy." Job was grieving, and the Lord reminded him our world began with singing.

The question reminds Job to think about the big picture. Our understanding of the pre-existence adds something to understanding our lives here. Job had lived before his birth, as we did, but he could not remember that life. John Taylor connected the singing and shouting to the council in heaven, when the Father presented the plan through which His children could receive bodies and grow toward exaltation. Brother Hammon taught us in devotional that we were there and that we answered. Understood that way, Job was hearing about a joy he had once shared but could no longer remember.

That is hard to imagine from where Job was sitting. Coming to earth had meant losing people he loved and suffering in a body that hurt. Yet receiving a body was part of what we had wanted. The Father already had a glorified body and a fullness we had not received. His plan gave us the opportunity to grow toward that fullness. It also required a Redeemer. We could come to earth and receive bodies, but we could not raise ourselves from the grave or

redeem ourselves from sin. The Son had promised to do that for us. Our hope in coming here depended on Him.

Abraham also knew the joy of looking forward to Christ. Jesus told the people in the temple that Abraham had seen His day and rejoiced. They objected that Jesus was not yet fifty years old. How could He have known Abraham? Jesus answered, "Before Abraham was, I am." His life reached back before His birth, and so did His promise to redeem us. Abraham's joy in Christ's coming helps me understand the joy John Taylor describes in the council: people rejoicing in what the Son would do before He had done it.

Adam's family learned to trust that promise through sacrifice. The book of Moses tells us that the Lord commanded Adam to offer the firstborn of his flocks. Adam obeyed, but he did not yet understand why. When an angel asked him the reason, Adam said he only knew that the Lord had commanded it. The angel explained that the offering represented the coming sacrifice of the Only Begotten.

For Adam, that lesson was also personal. Adam is Michael, our Father, and Jesus is His Only Begotten in the flesh. Like Abraham and Isaac, the offering on Adam's altar represented the sacrifice of His own Son. Adam's children were learning that their forgiveness and resurrection would depend on Christ.

They did not have to wait until Christ's birth to receive forgiveness. King Benjamin taught that those who believed Christ would come could receive a remission of their sins "even as though he had already come among them." Christ had covenanted with His Father to make the Atonement. His promise could be trusted by people who would live and die before His mortal life began.

John's vision of a war in heaven gives us another way to think about that trust. He describes the faithful overcoming Satan "by the blood of the Lamb, and by the word of their testimony." The conflict was premortal, and the blood had not yet been shed. We overcame by trusting the sacrifice Christ had promised to make.

But what does an earlier promise mean to someone sitting in ashes? It does not make the losses small. Job's children mattered. Believing in a resurrection would not make him stop missing them. And knowing that he

had chosen to come to earth would not explain every terrible thing that happened here.

Job still believed that his life would reach beyond what he was suffering. In the middle of the book, he said, "I know that my redeemer liveth." He looked forward to a day when he would see God in his flesh. He did not have an explanation for his losses. He had confidence in the Redeemer who could bring him through death.

I think that is where this reaches us. When I am having a hard week, I do not always feel like someone who once shouted for joy at the thought of coming here. I cannot remember what I understood then. There are things I do not understand now. But I can learn why I trusted the Father and the Son, and I can choose to trust Them again. Job's questions did not make his faith in his Redeemer meaningless. He could grieve, ask, and still believe.

On the night before His death, Jesus gave His disciples a way to remember Him. He broke bread, gave it to them, and told them it represented His body, which He would give for them. "This do in remembrance of me," He said. After His death, He told the Nephites that they should no longer offer sacrifices by shedding blood. The sacrifice those offerings had pointed toward was complete.

Adam's family stood at an altar and looked forward to what Christ would do. We take the sacrament and remember that He has done it. His promise was the reason we could rejoice at the thought of coming here, even though mortal life would include suffering. When the Lord spoke to Job about the morning stars singing, He brought that beginning into view again. Job's life had a purpose before he sat in the ashes, and that purpose has not disappeared. We need that reminder too. We cannot remember shouting for joy, but knowing that we did helps us make sense of a life that sometimes hurts. We wanted the opportunity to become like our Father, and we trusted His Son to make it possible. When I take the sacrament, I remember that the Savior we trusted has kept His promise. That gives me a reason to keep trusting Him now: "I know that my redeemer liveth."

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The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.